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KINSHIP SYSTEM • SOCIAL ORGANIZATION AND POLITICAL SYSTEM

SOCIAL ORGANIZATION AND POLITICAL SYSTEM

KINSHIP SYSTEM¹

The father is addressed as *baba* by his children and members of his children's age-sets. It is considered impolite to address him by his own name. The mother is addressed as *maito*, a term of great respect. Terms for son and daughter are *moro* and *mware* respectively.

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A wife addresses her husband as *muthuri wakwa* and he addresses her as *mutumia wakwa*.² These terms are extended to members of the husband's age-set and are reciprocated by these members. Tate states that husband and wife fall each other *murume* and *muka*.

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Full siblings, the bond between whom is "that of inseparables," call each other by the compound terms *moro wa maito* or *mware wa maito* (son or daughter of our mother). Half-siblings address each other as *moro wa baba* or *mware wa baba*.

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The father's elder brother is *baba mukuru* (great father), and his younger brother is *baba monyini* (little father). Brothers address each other's children as they do their own. The father's sister is *tata*, the term also used for the mother's sister. The father's sister is respected but "unlike her brothers, who are looked on as fathers and have supreme authority over the children, she has very little influence in affairs concerning the children or the homestead of her brothers, except in social functions." The mother's sister is said to be regarded with even more affection than the child's own mother. The mother's brother is *mama*. His position is clearly ambivalent. Kenyatta says that the

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relationship between a man and his sister's children is one of "fatherly love and affection," he "has a certain influence over the children" in that his permission is needed before their ears can be pierced at initiation, and that the children "would feel nervous of visiting him."

Parallel cousins are called *moro* or *mware* "of my elder or younger father" or "of my *tata*." The father's sister's child has a special term, *moihwa*, which is also used to refer to a sister's child. There is a strong bond with the *moihwa*, and a person should never pass a *moihwa*'s home without visiting and receiving food. Mother's brother's child is called son or daughter of *mama*, or *mama* and *tata*.

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Cousins

Grandfather is called *guuka* and grandmother *coco*. There is a great affection between grandparents and grandchildren, and "symbolically the children belong to the same age-group as their grandparents." A child is named after one of its grandparents and "in religious ceremonies the children are treated in the same manner as their grandparents." A boy is called "my husband" by his grandmother, and a girl "my co-wife"; the grandfather calls his grandson "my equal" and his granddaughter "my bride." It is implicit in Kenyatta's account that this is a joking relationship.

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Grandparents And
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An affine is referred to as *muthoni* "which means one who is bashful or polite"; the term applies to "all clan members" of families linked by marriage. *Muthoni* is apparently used between all affines except that a husband's brother is "given a nickname as a sign of endearment" by the wife, and he reciprocates, and the husband addresses his wife's sister as *maramu*.¹ The wife addresses her parents-in-law as father, *baba*, and mother, *maito*;² the husband refers to his parents-in-law as *muthoni*. The wife may call her husband's sister *wathurutia* and the husband's brother's wife *muiru*.

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¹ A full account of the Kikuyu kinship system is given by Kenyatta, 1938, pp. 9–18; a list of kinship terms is given by Tate, 1911, pp. 291–3. Unless otherwise stated, information is from Kenyatta, supported by Tate.

² *Muthuri* and *mutumia* are the terms commonly used for "elder" or "householder," and "woman with an initiated child" respectively.

¹ *Maramu* appears to be a reciprocal term.

² Tate also gives the terms *iciciara* (m.) and *nyaciara* (f.), the latter being a reciprocal.

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